

☉ The Oath of Crossed Blades

Where two stand, only one shall remain. I swear enmity unto thee until the last sun rises, shines, and sets forever. May my heart cease to beat, my hand lose its strength, and my eyes grow forever dim should I ever show thee favor. May the Dreaming, the stars, and the bones of the earth be my witnesses.

System: Usually taken only by trolls and sidhe, this oath represents an extreme step in the dance of courtly intrigue. Such an oath taking usually accompanies feuds and vendettas and may involve an entire house, a particular family, or a lone individual. The individual swearing this oath trades a Willpower point for one of Glamour and lowers by two the difficulty of any roll involving his enemy. Should he break the oath, he loses a Willpower dot and a scar in the form of two slashes, seemingly made by a rapier point, appear on his face, labeling the person as an oath breaker.

Should both parties desire to call off the oath, they must both agree to undertake a quest of atonement, usually involving the taking of the Oath of the Long Road at its beginning. Most of the other kiths eschew this oath, believing that announcing one's enmity toward someone or some people is counterproductive to carrying out plans to that person's detriment.

Banality

Glamour's counterweight, Banality is cold where Glamour is warm, hunger where Glamour is plenty, apathy where Glamour is hope. More than despair, it is an emptiness, a stasis, the lack of a drive to take life for anything more than a series of meaningless rote actions. Even sorrow and loss are emotions, charged with Glamour and inspiration — what Banality touches shivers and dies, though it puts up every appearance of living on. It is active apathy, a pervasive force of conformity that has infested the modern world.

Banality is a terrible enough foe for mortals, draining the joy from their lives, sometimes even turning them into walking beacons of the stuff that lashes out at the Dreaming wherever it may sniff it out. For changelings, Banality is 1,000 times worse, a creeping poison that slowly, over the course of a bright and brilliant life, steals that light away, locking it behind the Mists until, at last, the Kithain are left with no more than we remember of our own dreams when we rise each morning. Others, unaware of the Dreaming, pity them, thinking them senile or mad, but even this pity is no salve for the true tragedy this poor soul has suffered.

By The Numbers

Banality touches virtually everything in the World of Darkness, and therefore everything has a Banality rating. This rating represents, on a scale of 1 to 10 dots, just how much Banality has been invested into the subject. The higher the number, the more apathetic and unimaginative the person or thing in question is, generally speaking. It also measures how dangerous those individuals or objects might be to changelings, and how destructive to their Glamour they will be. A high Banality rating means that a changeling's Arts might slide right off



Banality and Mental Illness

While it is true that individuals with very low Banality are more likely to be diagnosed with a mental health condition or disorder simply for being different, Banality has no effect on mental health. There are people with mental health conditions at every level of Banality, and those conditions have little to no influence on their Banality ratings — they are no more or less Banal regardless of whether their condition is being treated or not.



that person, for example. **Mechanically, this means a subject with high Banality (8–10) adds +1 difficulty to cantrip rolls targeting them.**

The Storyteller should think about a character's backstory when deciding on her Banality rating. Was her creativity encouraged when she was growing up? Does she work in a field where thinking outside of the box is rewarded? How many books does she read in a year? Try to get a sense of the character's mindset, because ultimately that is the greatest determining factor in how high her Banality rating is.

Banality 1–3

Nothing in the modern world is free from Banality's influence, but Kithain treasure mortals with a Banality rating this low, as their minds and souls are comparatively untainted. Such individuals are called Dreamers, and are frequently used as sources of Glamour. Dreamers are unlikely to be held in high esteem by wider society, unless they're wealthy enough to be "eccentric" instead of "crazy" or have turned their overwhelming creative impulse to a popular end. Even if a Dreamer does enjoy wealth and popularity, she does not create because doing so brings these things to her — she creates because she *must*.

Banality 4–5

Individuals with a Banality of 4 or 5 are still passionately, even wildly creative by wider societal standards. They are likely to be known as flakes or idealists by their fellows, and may have difficulty maintaining day-to-day commitments that routinely interfere with their creative pursuits. They treasure any living situation that affords them the time they need to indulge in what they love. These are the sort of people who paint a perfect replica of the night sky on their ceiling "because they felt like it," or spend years of their lives painstakingly creating a patchwork map of a fantastic fictional world. While they are not Dreamers, they are still an excellent source of Glamour, and are much more likely to be understanding of the unusual pursuits of the Kithain.

Banality 6

People living with this level of Banality do what they can to resist the demands of the wider world around them, but cave